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"Being Black is not just some costume": how Black Americans narrate moral judgments regarding racial boundary-crossing

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Abstract

When is changing one's racial self-identification perceived as a moral vs. an immoral act? We examine this question using free responses drawn from a nationally representative survey of Black Americans (n = 760). To do so, we provided respondents with vignettes about a fictitious individual who has changed their racial self-identification after taking a genetic ancestry test. Further, we experimentally varied the context of the vignette between self-identification on (1) a census and (2) a college scholarship application. We find that respondents who frame responses using moral opposition tend to do so when they infer that the vignette individual is not self-identifying consistently across settings. This rejection is especially salient in scarce resource contexts—where there may be opportunities for strategic self-identification—but are not exclusive to them. In contrast, when identifications are assumed to reflect a permanent shift in identity (particularly one with a genuine embrace of Black culture and heritage), respondents instead validated the moral character of the vignette individual. We highlight a pattern that we term *racial consistency*: the perception that a change in one's racial identity can be morally justified if it is durable and persists regardless of any benefits or hardships experienced.

Keywords racial classification, race/ethnicity, moral judgements, boundary maintenance, genetic ancestry testing

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> *"It seems that everybody wants to be Black when it benefits them, but being Black is not just some costume you can take off at the end of the day. Will you proudly be Black when a cop pulls you over? Or when meeting your white partners family? Would you raise your children as Black? If the answers are no, then don't apply for the scholarship."*
>
> *Anonymous Respondent*

When is changing one's racial self-identification perceived as a moral vs. an immoral act? Social scientists have long conceptualized race as a multidimensional social construct that is based not only on how an individual self-identifies, but also on how observers perceive them (López et al. 2018; Omi and Winant 2014; Roberts 2011; Roth 2016). At the same time, such work highlights the potential for friction between these self-identifications and the classifications of third-party individuals, which has been made all the more complex with the advent of the burgeoning genetic ancestry test[1] (GAT) industry. Some 60 million Americans (approximately one in five) have used at-home GATs, such as those provided by *23andMe*, to trace the approximate geographic regions from which their ancestors originated (Orth 2022). The information provided by a GAT cannot tell anyone what their race is or is not (indeed, given the social nature of race, there is no such thing as a "true" or "correct" racial identification; Morning 2015). And yet, GAT information is often misunderstood by laypeople as they grapple with both their own racial self-identification and the identities of others (Roth and Ivemark 2018; Roth and Yaylacı 2024; Schachter, Flores, and Maghbouleh 2021; Trejo and Martschenko 2026). Further, in part due to the rigidity of the racial hierarchy in the United States that assigns status and resources on the basis of racial group membership (Gullickson 2010; Morning 2011), not all individual-level racial/ethnic changes carry the same implications or are equally likely to be accepted by members of the in-group (Oshotse, Berda, and Goldberg 2024).

This study examines the moral judgments that Black Americans craft in response to a fictitious individual newly identifying as Black after taking a GAT. While prior work grounded in theories of boundary-making, conflict, and status competition tends to focus on the reactions of high-status groups, such as the reactions of White Americans when they perceive a threat to the racial order and their own racial positions (Abascal 2020; Blumer 1958), the reactions of racial minority groups facing potential racial crossover have received comparatively less attention. We focus on the boundary defining Blackness in part due to its unique place in the U.S. racial hierarchy, which has historically been defined by strict legal principles and "one-drop" rules that continue to influence classification norms today (in spite of shifts to self-identification; Davis 2001). Furthermore, the United States has experienced dramatically shifted racial dynamics over the last 50 years. For example, in recent decades, affirmative action policies and pressure to address historical inequality have led to increased focus on the boundary around Blackness and the question of who ought to be able to benefit from such policies (Brubaker 2016b; Darity and Mullen 2022).

The norms governing responses to racial self-identifications are salient in a number of areas of American life, but they are especially so where perceptions of threat and scarce resources are highest, such as in higher education settings. In U.S. contexts, colleges and universities rely on self-reported race to determine group membership, and, unlike in countries such as Brazil, there are no verification measures that confirm whether an individual's reported race/ethnicity at the moment of application aligns with the ways that they might identify in other contexts or the ways that others perceive them (Bailey, Fialho, and Loveman 2018). Until June 2023, when the use of race-based affirmative action was overturned in the United States by the Supreme Court, about 35 percent of selective colleges and universities practiced some form of affirmative action that accounted for racial self-identification with historically marginalized and underrepresented racial/ethnic groups (Hirschman and Berrey 2017).

More recently, legal scholars and college administrators have expressed concern over the potential to misrepresent one's racial identity, experiences, and history in an effort to gain a presumed competitive advantage for educational and employment opportunities (Brubaker 2016b). For example, searches of *College Confidential*, an online forum for college applicants

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that has been used to study race in other sociological studies (see also Huang 2023), reveal a number of forum discussions with prospective applicants asking about the possibilities of using GAT results with trace amounts of sub-Saharan African or Indigenous American genetic similarity to racially identify as Black or Indigenous, and the potential ramifications if one were "caught." Beyond explicit attempts to mislead about one's background, however, there are also ambiguous social rules about how individuals on the margins ought to identify and in what contexts such identifications are appropriate. This is particularly relevant as individuals grapple with information such as GAT results, which in rare cases have been used by individuals as "proof" of racial membership (Brubaker 2016b; Morning 2018).

Drawing from literatures that focus on the construction and policing of racial/ethnic boundaries and the moral judgments that enforce these divisions (Alba 2005; Lamont and Molnár 2002; Telles and Sue 2009; Wimmer 2008), this study examines how people respond to changes in racial self-identification that are precipitated by a GAT. In other words, we are interested in perceptions of social rules that maintain boundaries, thereby embedding an *individual* shift in racial self-identification within a broader, *social* process of racial construction. The data from this study are drawn from a companion project documenting the role of GATs and other attributes in shaping racial classifications by Black Americans (Thompson et al. 2026). The larger study comprised a nationally representative survey experiment with both quantitative and qualitative components. The present study focuses on a subset of the qualitative free text responses (n = 760), which include respondents' written reactions to a vignette featuring a fictitious individual who had not previously identified as Black but learned from a GAT that they have a small amount of sub-Saharan African (SSA) ancestry. Respondents were randomly assigned to read either that (1) the individual then went on to identify as Black on the census or (2) the individual applied for a college scholarship intended for Black students.

We illustrate that, rather than solely a specific response to scarce resource contexts or the threat of racial boundary crossing, respondents often base their moral judgments on presumptions of racial stability. That is, those who reject such identifications tend to do so when they assume a level of individual inconsistency on the part of the boundary-crosser. This appeared particularly salient in scarce resource contexts, where respondents highlighted perceived opportunities for strategic racial self-identification given the material stakes involved, but negative judgments were not exclusive to these situations. In contrast, when identifications were assumed to reflect a permanent, consistent shift in self-identification, particularly one that was perceived to accompany a genuine embrace of Black culture and heritage, respondents were less likely to express written disapproval of an identity change, regardless of context. Surprisingly, we find that in some cases respondents validated vignette individuals who had changed their racial identification to identify as Black on a scholarship if they believed that the individual would continue to identify as Black in the future.

In this study, we identify a pattern that we term *racial consistency*, which details the situations under which a change in one's racial identity is described as socially and morally acceptable. In brief, racial consistency describes a perception that a change in racial self-identification is permissible only when it is durable, regardless of any instrumental benefit that might be gained and in spite of any hardships that might then be faced. Furthermore, we identify that observers consider their perceptions of both *internal consistency* and *external appraisals* in making moral judgments: internal consistency considers the vignette individuals' self-identification over time (i.e., whether they will continue to identify the same way in the future), while external appraisal describes the perceived likelihood that other third-party observers will classify them as Black and welcome them into the Black community. Taken together, these results shed light on the multidimensional process of constructing and maintaining racial boundaries, which has become all the more complex in the post-genomic era.

Background

Social scientists generally conceptualize race as a social characteristic that is, for some, fluid and dynamic in nature (Anders et al. 2025; Davenport 2020; Saperstein and Penner 2014). While, at present, most Americans tend to have relatively stable racial/ethnic self-identifications over their lifetimes, evidence from Liebler et al. (2017) illustrates that, overall, about six percent of individuals in linked U.S. Census data changed either their racial or ethnic identities between the 2000 and 2010 censuses (even when accounting for changing formats over the years). However, individual changes in racial self-identification do not always represent a permanent shift in a given individual's identification: some have racial identities that change based on the social context (Harris and Sim 2002). Further, people who are racially ambiguous or who may have claims to multiple racial groups have increasingly "flexible ethnicities," or the ability to identify with—and be validated by—multiple racial/ethnic groups over time or across contexts (Vasquez 2010). As such, people may selectively integrate parts of their identity in order to find acceptance or play up different parts of their identities to suit the context.

However, boundary crossings are heterogeneous and may be made for a myriad of reasons. For example, Flores, Loría, and Casas (2023) identified two forms of individual-level racial boundary crossing: "transitory," which refers to short-term changes in racial/ethnic self-identification, and "durable," which describes more lasting shifts that may have slowly developed over time. Each is undergirded by different forces and connections to the broader racial/ethnic group, and each explains different levels of demographic change in a given population. In studying racial boundary shifts across entire populations, Flores et al. examined the sharp increases in the indigenous populations of Mexico, which were not, in fact, related to underlying demographic trends but rather to changing likelihoods of indigenous identification. While these patterns have been identified among *those doing the boundary crossing*, we know much less about *how such individuals are received* by members of the in-group.

Just as racial identities shift within individuals over time, racial boundaries are themselves subjective: entire racial groups may also experience boundary changes as political tides shift, census categories are introduced, or social movements emphasize new panethnic identities and bring together populations that may not have previously thought of themselves as ethnically similar (Davenport 2020; Telles and Sue 2009). A number of features of a given racial/ethnic boundary can shape the likelihood that an individual is socially permitted to cross it. One such feature is the extent to which a given person is likely to be classified as a member of a given racial group by external observers. Racial classification logics are complex in nature and shape key mechanisms of stratification such as discrimination (Abascal et al. 2025; Feliciano 2016; Schachter et al. 2021). Prior work on these topics have shown that a number of dimensions—including GAT results and other measures related to one's presumed ancestry—shape how individuals classify others across contexts (Abascal et al. 2025; Schachter et al. 2021; Thompson et al. 2026). In particular, reactions to GATs offer a theoretically generative setting for understanding racial classification norms. Unlike one's phenotype or cultural practices, GAT results can be suddenly acquired and even presented as a form of documentation; further, the scientific framing of results might lead some to view GATs as a more legitimate form of evidence compared to other factors (Roth and Ivemark 2018; Thompson et al. 2026).

Finally, this study focuses specifically on the ways that Black Americans draw moral boundaries in classifying others. Black Americans, both as the targets of classification and as the classifiers, occupy a unique place in the U.S. racial structure. In particular, the history and legacy of the "one-drop" rule, which created a legal system of hypodescent that instituted strict classifications for who was to be considered Black, continues to influence classification norms surrounding the Black community (Davis 2001). Today, both presumed ancestry and GAT results influence observer classifications by both Black and non-Black observers (Roberts, Bareket-Shavit, and Wang 2021; Schachter et al. 2021; Thompson et al. 2026). Further, while the U.S. racial structure encompasses

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a number of racial groups, the White-Black binary is widely considered to represent the starkest racial division (Lee and Bean 2012; Omi and Winant 2014).

Racial boundaries and moral judgments

Sociologists have long been interested in the study of the symbolic boundaries and moral judgments that people use to distinguish between in-groups and out-groups (Lamont and Molnár 2002). These collective identities shape the characteristics that are perceived to define a given group, including the cognitive divisions and perceptions that create racial/ethnic boundaries. In drawing and maintaining racial/ethnic boundaries, groups on either side of a divide negotiate group membership through social interactions with themselves and outsiders (Lamont and Molnár 2002; Omi and Winant 2014; Wimmer 2008). Racial boundaries may either be "bright" and perceived to be unambiguous or "blurred" and therefore subject to permeability (Alba 2005). As a result, the social characteristics of a given boundary define whether or not individual-level fluidity is thought to be possible.

In classification systems with strict hierarchies and status differences, people often draw moral distinctions between themselves and members of out-groups, focusing on defining which actions (and therefore which people) are morally good, while singling out those on the other side of a boundary divide as morally bad (Lamont and Molnár 2002). Such boundaries can be used both by high-status groups to validate their own position atop a hierarchy (Abascal 2020; Lamont 2000), but also by those who have been structurally disadvantaged as they strive to create group dignity and reframe hierarchies to position themselves as the truly moral (and therefore higher status) group (Lamont 2000; Vasquez and Wetzel 2009). At the same time, normative beliefs and judgments shed light on the social rules that govern a particular division. Such judgments lend legitimacy to a particular racial identification, which, in turn, contributes to upholding the racial system altogether as people police boundaries based both on their own values as well as their perceptions of how the broader community norms operate.

When are racial boundaries likely to be seen as bright or blurry? Prior research suggests a number of features about a given group and a given target (i.e., the individual attempting to cross the boundary) that shape the likelihood of validation or rejection. One such feature is the extent to which classifiers perceive a threat to status or resources by the boundary-crosser. In particular, theories of group conflict posit that competition over scarce resources—whether real or imagined—can lead to intergroup conflict, discrimination, and even differences in classification outcomes (Blumer 1958; Bobo and Hutchings 1996). For example, studies have found that White Americans are more likely to enforce strict racial boundaries—and reject fluidity or boundary crossing—when faced with perceived status threats to the racial order (Abascal 2020). As a result, classifiers may be particularly sensitive to boundary crossing that can be construed as instrumental or fleeting, a hypothesis which we examine in this work. While boundary crossing for a gain in status or resources may be viewed negatively by classifiers, such rejection may be heightened if the change is viewed as fleeting and therefore explicitly for personal gain. For this reason, we examine moral reactions to boundary crossing (an individual change in self-identification from non-Black to Black) in both scarce resource settings (e.g., a competitive college scholarship intended for Black students) and in settings where individual resources are less likely to be perceived as scarce, or where it may even be viewed as politically advantageous to increase numeric counts (e.g., a government census).

Data and methods

Data from this study are drawn from a larger companion study that investigates the role of GATs and other attributes in shaping racial classifications (Thompson et al. 2026). The original study comprises a pre-registered original survey vignette experiment, fielded in January 2023 on YouGov with a nationally representative sample of 3100 U.S.-born Black Americans. The

overarching study included a 2x2x2 experiment, where respondents each read a vignette about a fictitious individual who had taken a GAT; however, for the purposes of this article, we focus on only one of these treatment arms (therefore focusing only on a subset of these respondents, n = 760).[2] Figure A1 in the online appendix illustrates a flowchart of the various treatment arms in the overarching study.

We include both respondents who were randomly assigned to read about an individual identifying as Black on the census and on a scholarship application. Therefore, context is the only source of variation in these vignettes. Respondents began the study by viewing an image of the fictitious individual (see appendix for images) and reading the following prompt.

> *Meet Daniel.*[3] *Daniel is an American citizen whose family has been in the U.S. for generations. Daniel is usually unsure of how to identify, but mostly has not identified as Black/African-American.*
>
> *Daniel recently received his genetic ancestry test results from a company such as 23andMe or Ancestry.com. Genetic ancestry tests use a person's DNA to make an informed guess regarding where a person's ancestors lived. Daniel's genetic ancestry test results estimate that he has approximately 4% Sub-Saharan African ancestry (from countries such as Ghana and Nigeria) and 96% non-African ancestry.*
>
> *A few weeks after receiving these genetic ancestry test results, Daniel [filled out a government census and identified as Black/African-American / applied for a college scholarship intended for Black/African-American students (e.g., NAACP)].*

For the purposes of this article, we focus on respondents who were assigned to read a vignette about an individual whose GAT suggested that they had four percent sub-Saharan African genetic similarity (and 96 percent non-African genetic similarity) who had not previously identified as Black. In this way, we limit the focus of our study to those who are directly responding to a situation where an individual is crossing racial boundaries and who had very little sub-Saharan African genetic similarity information displayed on their GAT result.[4]

We then asked several questions about how respondents perceived the vignette individual's decision to identify as Black, measured using both quantitative outcomes and open-ended text responses. The quantitative results of this study are analyzed in a separate article. Descriptive statistics of the analytic sample (n = 760 respondents) can be found below in Table 1, along with information on the measured quantitative outcomes. Rather than focusing on quantitative measures of approval/disapproval, our goal is to understand the narration of moral judgments and the language used to validate or reject the vignette individual.

Importantly, with the exception of the context in which the individual was identifying as Black, all respondents read identical information. Thus, any specific response that focused on the consistency (or lack thereof) of the individual's decision to identify as Black was inferred by the respondent rather than included directly as a treatment. All of the images in the study are drawn from the Chicago Face Database (Ma, Correll, and Wittenbrink 2015); we intentionally selected several racially ambiguous images based on the norming data and pretests with Black respondents. We pretested these images to ensure that they were perceived to be comparable in their levels of racial ambiguity. Importantly, the experimental effects of the various images are substantively quite similar. Our goal of using multiple similar images is to ensure that the patterns we uncover are valid over a range of comparable images, as using only one image might limit the generalizability of our findings. Further, we selected names that signaled White-Black ambiguity using birth data for the state of New York. Like the images, these names were selected to send similar signals to respondents and are not intended as a source of variation.[5] More information on the images and names can be found in the appendix.

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Table 1 Summary statistics of survey respondents.

	Mean/Prop.	SD
Age	45.70	16.86
Female	.58	
Education		
No High School	.07	
High School Graduate	.33	
Some College	.24	
2-Year Degree	.13	
Four-Year Degree	.15	
Post-Grad	.08	
Household Income ($1000)	48.54	62.11
Immigration Background		
Parents & Grandparents Born in US	.89	
Parents Born in US	.04	
Parents Immigrants to US	.07	
Political Party		
Democrat	.59	
Republican	.08	
Independent	.23	
Other / Not Sure	.09	

Notes: n = 760. All respondents self-identified as Black / African American.

Finally, to solicit the free-response text data used in this manuscript, we included the following free response questions:

(1) *We are interested in your beliefs on what it means for a person to be Black/African-American. In your opinion, what are the characteristics, experiences, attitudes, and values that define being Black/African-American?*
(2) *How do you feel about Daniel identifying as Black/African-American [on the government census / for a college scholarship intended for Black/African-American students] after taking a genetic ancestry test? Please specify your reactions, thoughts, and emotions about his decision.*

Respondents provided written text in response to both questions, which we then analyzed to understand how and when moral judgments are made.[6] Given our interest in understanding how moral boundaries are drawn, much of the analysis draws from the second question, though we include responses to both questions in our analyses. If participants provided an empty response or a response with fewer than 100 characters, they were prompted once with a request for written text. However, participants could bypass this response after the first attempt. On average, respondents wrote about 60 words in response to our questions (about 30 words per question), ranging from a minimum of 6 total words to 767 total words (see Table 2).

Analytic strategy

We conduct an abductive qualitative analysis of the free response texts generated by the experiment in the focal conditions (n = 760; Tavory and Timmermans 2014). At its core, abductive inquiry focuses on findings that are surprising in light of existing empirical and theoretical

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Table 2 Word counts (text responses).

	Mean	SD
Define Being Black	31.38	28.85
Reaction to Decision	27.32	21.09
Total	58.70	45.32

Table 3 Quantitative outcomes, by treatment group.

	Census		Scholarship	
	Mean/Prop.	SD	Mean/Prop.	SD
Racial Classification = Black	.57		.53	
Approval	4.66	1.81	4.40	2.14

Notes: Racial classification is a binary variable of whether the respondent classified the vignette individual as Black. Approval is measured on a 7-point Likert scale from extremely negative to extremely positive. n = 760.

literatures. This investigation was guided in part by unexpected findings in the quantitative companion study, which found that context affected approval of the vignette individual, but did not affect how individuals classify that same individual. That is, whether a respondent read about an individual identifying as Black on the census or about an individual identifying as Black and applying for a college scholarship did not have a causal effect on whether or not respondents themselves classified the individual as Black. These findings were contrary to expectations drawn from theories of boundary-making and group conflict, which suggest that, among racial minority groups, attitudes towards boundary-crossers are likely to be negative in cases where there is a perceived threat to scarce resources, which we would expect to then shape classification (Blumer 1958; Huang 2023). Table 3 includes the average values of the quantitative outcome variables for the analytic sample for this study (n = 760), separated by treatment group. Further, Table A1 in the appendix reproduces the main effects from the nationally representative sample of 3100 Black Americans for both the classification and approval outcomes (see also Thompson et al. 2026).

To disentangle how Black Americans draw moral boundaries across these conditions, we first examined all of the comments across both of the free response prompts, focusing our coding in NVivo on findings that spoke to the underlying mechanisms that might explain when and why respondents reacted with moral approval or disapproval to the racial self-identification of the vignette individual across the two contexts and when this approval aligned or did not align with their classifications. Next, we conducted open coding, noting when and how context conditions led to differences in reactions, and the assumptions that were baked into these free text responses by respondents. We focused our coding on the ways that moral approval or disapproval were narrated. During this process, the presumed consistency of the individual's response quickly emerged as a key feature underlying how respondents reacted. We further observed that perceptions differed based on whether the individual was perceived to be behaving in an internally consistent manner as well as whether a respondent believed that other external observers would be likely to classify them consistently. To further develop the theory discussed in this manuscript, we cycled between the existing literature, the data itself, and our codes and analysis notes. Finally, though our design includes random assignment, we conceptualize our results in this study as descriptive. Our qualitative interpretations focus on how respondents

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morally frame authenticity across conditions, not on the effect of treatment assignment on outcomes. In a separate article, we employ computational text analysis methods on these same data, allowing for causal estimation of treatment effects on measured outcomes across the entire data corpus (Thompson et al., 2026).

Results

Respondents' free text responses illustrate the moral boundaries and enforcement of social norms that people use in responding to the scenario of a (fictitious) individual attempting to identify as Black after previously identifying with a different, non-Black racial identity. Through our analysis of the free text responses, we identified three features that broadly characterized respondents' written reactions to the vignette individual: (1) scarce resources and the context in which the vignette individual has identified as Black; (2) whether or not the vignette individual is perceived to be likely to be consistent in his or her self-identification in the future; and (3) whether or not third party observers will be likely to classify the vignette individual as Black. These criteria and the extent to which respondents engaged with them in crafting moral judgments form the core of our analysis.

In particular, our theoretical contribution highlights the intertwined nature of the second and third dimensions highlighted above, which together shed light on racial consistency. Figure 1 illustrates our conceptual approach. First, respondents may consider a given individual's *internal consistency*: whether they will continue to identify with a given racial/ethnic group in both good and bad times. Second, respondents may also consider *external appraisal*: the perception of how third-party observers will classify a given person. What happens when the two are in conflict? We find that, while respondents view flexible or strategic racial self-identification as morally wrong, they tend to be more forgiving if they assume there will be approval and validation from the broader Black community. As a result, (presumed) external appraisal may, at times, override internal inconsistency because the perceptions of others (above and beyond even an individual's own self-identification) shape how a given person is treated by society.

Context, scarce resources, and racial threat

Before we detail our findings on racial consistency, we begin with a discussion of the role of context in informing sense-making among respondents. As expected, the social context in which the vignette individual identified as Black prompted meaningful distinctions in how respondents reacted. In particular, we observed that the mention of the scholarship condition in the vignette often prompted individuals to emphasize the scholarship context in their written responses. In contrast, the census condition seemed to function as a more neutral (and, at times, seemingly invisible) condition where respondents were more likely to emphasize other aspects of the vignette individual's background when assigned to these conditions, without explicitly mentioning the census.

Consistent with prior theory, some respondents viewed the target individual's application for the scholarship as a potential threat to scarce resources that should, in respondents' minds, be reserved for more deserving members of the Black community. Considerations about the context and the perceived instrumental use of the scholarship anchored how some respondents narrated the morality of the vignette individual's decision. For example, one respondent wrote the following in reacting to the vignette:

> *This is why so many Blacks have such a hard time in life, Ava feels that she is entitled to this grant when she is not. She is taking away an opportunity for a Black student to have a chance at college. Once she gets her degree she will not identify as Black in the real world because her chances are better if she doesn't. She is playing the system to her advantage.*[7]

		Internally Consistent Self-Identification	
		Yes	**No**
External Appraisal	**Yes**	**Example:** The target individual consistently identifies as Black and most external observers will consistently classify them as Black. **Outcome:** Respondent approval	**Example:** The target individual does not consistently identify as Black, but most external observers will consistently classify them as Black. **Outcome:** Likely respondent approval (positive external appraisals may override internal inconsistency)
	No	**Example:** The target individual consistently identifies as Black, but external observers are unlikely to classify them as Black. **Outcome:** Likely respondent approval (respondent validates internally consistent racial self-identification)	**Example:** The target individual does not consistently identify as Black and external observers are unlikely to classify them as Black. **Outcome:** Respondent disapproval

Figure 1 Racial consistency conceptual framework. We model this figure from Correll et al.'s (2020) exploration of the Viewing and Valuing Social Cognitive Process Model.

Here, the respondent focuses on several aspects of the vignette individual's identity that each shape how the respondent engages with the question of moral legitimacy. First, she is perceived to be "taking away an opportunity for a Black student to have a chance at college," which suggests the perception of a zero-sum opportunity for a single student to receive the scholarship. If the vignette individual receives it, by this logic, another student cannot. Not only does the respondent believe that the vignette individual is leveraging her racial self-identification to take opportunities from another, potentially more deserving person, but the respondent also believes that the only reason for her self-identification is to play "the system to her advantage." This instrumental use of one's self-identification, as perceived by the respondent, informs the moral rejection. Finally, as we will examine in more detail in later sections, the respondent's rejection also highlights the perceived instability of her self-identification: this fact appeared particularly important in drawing the distinction between a moral act of racial identity change relative to an immoral one.

Across comments, respondents balanced concerns about the scarce resources at play and perceived threats to the ability of other Black individuals to take advantage of similar scholarships if more racially ambiguous self-identifications (such as the identification of the vignette individual) were socially validated. Along these lines, one respondent wrote, "*If you're white, you're white. He's taking away the opportunity that another black person may have needed.*" In particular, reactions highlighted that respondents did not perceive this to be a victimless act; not only were actions rejected as morally wrong, but they were perceived to be morally wrong because of their unfairness towards other individuals with more legitimate and stable claims to Blackness. In succinct terms, one respondent highlighted their perception of the goal of the scholarship and the scarce resources at stake: "*If the scholarship is only available to a limited number of applicants*

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and is intended to help students to overcome specific societal obstacles, someone who doesn't face those obstacles morally shouldn't take the spot of someone who does."

Often, respondents focused narrowly on the perceived instrumental nature of the decision to identify as Black to apply for the scholarship. That the target individual may have something to gain by identifying as Black shaped the ways that respondents wrote about their perceptions and judgments. For example, one respondent commented "*I think she is just applying for the scholarship to get the money and shouldnt be considered*," while another wrote "*I feel he would have never told anyone about his 4% African DNA if the scholarship wasn't involved.*" In all, about ten percent of respondents wrote documents that referenced a selective or instrumental use of the vignette individual's self-identification. These responses were much more prevalent among those in the scholarship condition, reflecting the influence of context on reactions.

Internal (In)consistency

However, not all perceived instrumental uses of the scholarship application were rejected by respondents. Instead, some respondents made inferences about the relative consistency of the target individual's self-identification in order to enact moral judgments around when and how such a person might be socially permitted to identify as Black. Importantly, the vignette prompts themselves did not distinguish between a temporary or permanent shift in the target's racial identity and referred only to a point-in-time shift after taking a GAT; respondents then layered perceptions of consistency (or inconsistency) onto their perceptions of the individual, suggesting that this type of moral judgment was both automatically deployed and key to their decision-making process.

In previous examples, respondents highlighted the perceived instrumental nature of the vignette individual's decision. However, across responses, we observed meaningful nuance in how people navigated the moral nature of this decision. For example, one respondent noted both the presumed fleeting nature of the vignette individual's self-identifications and the ways in which they perceived that the vignette individual was taking resources away from students who were potentially more deserving:

> *I would take issue with Andrew hypothetically applying for this scholarship. If he never identified as Black, knew he had African ancestry, or was treated as a Black person in society, it would be very wrong to take that away from someone else. The scholarship is clearly intended to lift up Black students who have historically had a harder time acquiring higher education because of systemic discrimination. Andrew presumably faced no racism, as he only just found out he had Black ancestry. So he doesn't need the same lifting up and help that other Black students need. I would be upset about it if this was a real life example. It seems that everybody wants to be Black when it benefits them, but being Black is not just some costume you can take off at the end of the day. Will you proudly be Black when a cop pulls you over? Or when meeting your white partners family? Would you raise your children as Black? If the answers are no, then don't apply for the scholarship.*

Here, the respondent strongly rejects the target's decision to identify as Black on the scholarship because it is presumed to be a temporary shift specifically for material gain. Because the target individual has not experienced racial discrimination (and is not presumed to be willing to face discrimination by consistently self-identifying as Black in the future), it is—according to the respondent—wrong to apply for the scholarship. In doing so, the respondent highlights the importance of being "proudly" Black under difficult circumstances and keeping a stable racial self-identification moving forward. The idea of Blackness as something that is not a "costume" or an optional part of one's identity also appeared in other responses: "*being black is not an on and off switch that you can just turn off, it's your whole life.*"

Likewise, other respondents drew a similar series of moral boundaries that centered on the presumed consistency of the target individual's self-identification. For example, consider the following two responses:

> *It depends. If Sam is genuinely embracing and exploring this aspect of her heritage in all parts of her life, then I might feel that the scholarship application is one part of a larger life transformation for her. However, if Sam doesn't embrace and own this aspect of her genetic heritage but only uses it strategically for material gain, then I might she [sic] the application as disingenuous…*
>
> *… . Most people are aware of their ancestry to some extent, as it has been told to them by their family. If she was not aware it is probably because some in her family chose to deny it. Claiming to be black for the scholarship is akin to taking the good without experiencing any of the bad.*

As with respondents quoted in earlier passages, the key feature of the target individual's decision to apply for the scholarship is not the potential material gain that they may stand to gain, but rather the extent to which they are willing to embrace *all* of the aspects of what it means to be Black in the United States today rather than "taking the good without experiencing any of the bad." In this sense, respondents created a series of scope conditions that shaped likelihoods of moral validation or rejection. For example, the above respondent clearly lays out the conditions in which "it depends:" Either the vignette individual is genuine (and therefore motivated to identify as Black in all contexts, regardless of the social cost), or she is disingenuous and taking undue advantage of the situation and its material stakes.

These sentiments were echoed across comments, with other respondents writing "*If that's how she identifies, that's fine UNLESS she's applying for benefits entitled to Blacks only, then it's wrong"* and *"If he doesn't identify like that all the time then don't do it when its convenient or profitable to do so.*" In these cases, respondents were clear that they perceived it to be wrong to change one's self-identification for personal gain, without the experience of discrimination or inequality that might accompany such a shift: "*One must live that experience and be a part of it in order to identify as a part of that group. Too many people take advantage of this when it is advantageous for them, but wouldn't identify that way in a more difficult situation."*

On the other hand, when respondents inserted a presumed consistency into the target individual's decision to identify as Black, they then appeared much more likely to validate the decision in their responses, regardless of the context and the fact that the respondent had changed racial self-identifications. This was demonstrated in respondent reactions that highlighted their pride and positive emotions about the target individual's decision, which were emphasized as morally good due to consistency and for genuinely embracing a potentially difficult racial identity that could open one up to discrimination and persecution. In these cases, respondents instead focused on their positive emotions and moral validations:

> *He must be proud of his 4%. I'm proud of him. Identifying as black says no matter what I'm here no matter the persecution, racial profiling, untimely deaths and murders from our own and from police. . .*

Likewise, another respondent also foregrounded the perceived stability of the target's decision and how this influenced their reaction:

> *My reactions are positive as he's CHOSEN to be black, despite how I feel most people in his position would. There's a stigma that comes with being black and it's not a good one. So, I appreciate him for that.*

Here, in contrast to prior excerpts where respondents rebuffed the idea that an inconsistent target individual could be socially permitted to identify as Black, respondents were positive and even welcoming of an individual with a consistent self-identification. Both respondents praise the permanence of this decision, even as they acknowledge that it is the target individual's choice given their perceived ambiguity. If the vignette individual identifies as Black "no matter what," even in spite of the potential for personal persecution, respondents tended to consider

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this a positive and moral decision. Surprisingly, this praise extended to some individuals in the scholarship condition, suggesting that it is not the change in racial identification or the scarce resources per se that shaped rejection, but rather the perception that the vignette individual might quickly stop identifying as Black in the future.

Across comments, these sentiments were echoed by other respondents: "*I'm fine if this is who he believes himself to be and lived that out"* and "*I love that Zoe applied to a school that is specifically for us. I'm glad she found our her family history and background. I was happy that she got to connect to her ancestors even more during that process. .. I'm proud of Zoe.*" These excerpts also highlight that presumptions of internal consistency often prompted feelings of pride in the respondents. Indeed, several respondents suggested that their positive feelings about the vignette individual stemmed from the fact that the vignette individual was viewed as having pride in his/her racial identity and genuinely embracing Black culture and heritage. Still, even where respondents expressed some skepticism of the vignette individual's decision, the presumption of a stable racial identification shaped whether they viewed it as morally right or wrong: "*Great as long as she's really black and not trying to pass for black everybody wants to be black until they get treated like a black person in American society.*"

Importantly, in each vignette, the fictitious individual is identifying as Black, did not identify as Black in the past, and is doing so after taking a GAT that revealed four percent Sub-Saharan African ancestry. And yet, respondent assumptions differed meaningfully across cases, which led to differences in the likelihoods of positive reactions and interpretations. Indeed, the presumptions themselves shed light on what appears to be a highly salient feature of these moral judgments: the perceived consistency of one's racial self-identification. All told, about 18 percent of respondents highlighted some form of a presumption regarding internal (in)consistency—a sizeable fraction of the response pool given that consistency was not an assigned treatment arm. Further, inconsistency and disapproval were more common in the scholarship condition (though not unique to it), while consistency was more common in the census condition.

Can external appraisals override internal inconsistency?

Respondents focused not only on perceptions of internal consistency on the part of the target individual, but also on the extent to which third-party observers might classify them as Black across contexts, suggesting an additional focus on the assumptions about third-party observer classifications. Though target individuals themselves may have been perceived as transient in their identifications, if respondents viewed their external classifications as relatively fixed (i.e., that there was essentially no choice to be made on the part of the target, as they would always be widely classified by third party observers as Black), they tended to be more permissive in their written reactions, even in cases where the scholarship prompted a perception of instrumental use of Blackness for material gain. Illustrating this point in succinct terms, one respondent wrote:

> *She looks African American, therefore society is going to classify her as such, so why not take advantage of resources that are being offered.*

Here, the respondent uses external classification to argue that—in spite of the fact that the target individual is attempting to cross racial boundaries and identify as Black—if her observed race is generally Black either way, then she is within her moral rights to apply for scholarships as she sees fit. Likewise, other respondents made a similar argument that rested on appearance and the perceived judgments of third-party observers:

> *I am ok what she did because people are judged by what they look like, therefore she might as well let her documents reflect what people is going to see when they meet her.*
> *We know before we take any test what people think of you, when looking at your skin colo [sic]*

This suggests that consistent external classifications can, in fact, override an internally inconsistent racial self-identification if one's appearance is perceived to be relatively unambiguous.

On the other hand, when respondents subjectively viewed the physical appearance of the target individual as suggesting a consistent *non-Black* racial identity, they also tended to be less forgiving of perceived boundary crossing. For example, one respondent, in writing about their moral rejection of the vignette individual, wrote:

> *Emily looks non African American. Yes she may be a minority. But there are plenty scholarships for her descendants. I'm deeply disappointed that she doesn't identify with what she strongly represents*

Across conditions, respondents identified a second form of consistency that functioned irrespective of how individuals themselves might self-identify: third-party observer classification. If the target individuals' observed race remained generally consistent, the boundary of Blackness could be crossed in self-identification. This was echoed by other commenters, as with the individual who wrote: "*She is not black enough by appearance. She can pass for latin. She can pass for white.*" Importantly, external classifications featured less prominently in responses than internal consistency, with only about eight percent of respondents referencing this theme.

Of course, the respondents in our study—a nationally representative sample of Black Americans—were also heterogeneous in their responses. In addition to the patterns indicated above, we also observed that a number of respondents rejected the idea that a moral judgment was theirs to make (for example, "*Andrew has the right to see himself as he chooses without anyone else telling him how he should see himself*"; ten percent of the respondents). Likewise, a subset of respondents referenced the GAT and indicated either that they perceived the percentage to be too low or that there was a specific threshold that they believe would make the identification more appropriate: "*A person should be at least 50% African*", "*I think honestly if your percentage is over 25% and you carry african american traits such as curly hair, darker tone, shorter hair, and other small charatistics [sic] for an african american. I believe those are some good starting values for it.*" Twelve percent of respondents included some sort of reference to the GAT in this manner. While these additional patterns shed light on the range of beliefs and judgments made by respondents, we focus this article and discussion on the role of racial consistency in shaping moral boundaries.

Discussion

In this study, we develop the concept of *racial consistency* to explain how third-party observers judge the morality of changing one's racial self-identification across both scarce and non-scarce resource contexts. As we have shown, respondents generally rebuff a perceived short-lived change in identity, particularly if it is viewed as strategic on the part of the (fictitious) boundary crosser. In contrast, a durable change that is assumed to include an embracement of the broader culture and heritage—even if it might bring racial hardship and discrimination— tended to be validated. Surprisingly, our results highlight that there exist some cases where respondents both perceive a scarcity of resources and yet validate the vignette individual's self-identification decision. While these differences generally characterized responses, we observe that assumptions based on appearance also matter: when respondents assume that the vignette individual will be externally classified as Black, their individual self-identification was less emphasized in written reactions. These judgments, in turn, shed light on the negotiation process that defines racial boundaries: in defining who *is* perceived as part of the broader Black community, we also learn much about who *is not* perceived as such.

Together, these results speak to the intertwined nature of one's racial identification and how others classify them (López et al. 2018; Roth 2016). While individual self-identifications are strongly correlated with how people are viewed by others, they are not perfectly overlapping. However, while average rates of racial mismatch have been established by prior studies (Vargas

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and Stainback 2016), it is important to also embed this process within the wider, social processes that govern racial appraisals. What happens when there is friction between how an individual self-identifies and how others perceive them, or if an individual changes their racial identification? By demonstrating the dimensions that shape moral judgments, we aim to better understand how and when fluidity or racial change is likely to be accepted more broadly by a given community. This study builds upon prior work that has examined how people make racial classifications in context, and the ways that people narrate these choices and norms (Abascal 2020; Abascal et al. 2024; Davenport 2020; Feliciano 2016; Schachter et al. 2021). These norms, as we demonstrate, extend not only to situations where the target individual is perceived as acting in a morally permissive and authentic manner, but also to situations where such authenticity may even be discounted because respondents believe that others will perceive the target individual as Black anyway.

Our results build upon a vast body of work on the porosity of boundaries and the ways that they emerge from negotiations and power struggles on both sides of the divide (Alba and Nee 2005; Wimmer 2008). By establishing the conditions under which boundary-crossers are likely to be validated, rather than rebuffed, by the in-group we shed light on the ways that people think about race and the permissibility of fluidity. The United States is growing increasingly multiracial; as more and more individuals have the option to potentially change their self-identification or otherwise cross racial boundaries, it becomes increasingly important to understand how they might be received (Anders et al. 2025; DaCosta 2020; Liebler et al. 2017). Further, though rates of racial switching after taking a GAT are low (Roth and Yaylacı 2024), the broad accessibility of GATs—which grow less and less expensive to produce and therefore more and more available to consumers—may shape future likelihoods of boundary crossing. Finally, given that much of the prior work on questions related to classification and boundaries has focused on White Americans, an important contribution of our work is that we focus on how Black Americans specifically engage with the perceived boundary around Blackness.

We focus these results on one context in which there are both scarce resources and the potential incentive to cross racial boundaries in order to take advantage: higher education. Given the status of affirmative action and broader DEI policy as political lightning rods, these results likely represent a strong test of a case where there might exist moral objection. While *Students for Fair Admissions* overturned the explicit use of race-based considerations in higher education admissions, policies focusing on racial/ethnic diversity are unlikely to disappear entirely. For example, in the decision that overturned the use of race-based affirmative action, the justices suggested that essays could be used to narrate experiences of racial hardship, alongside other difficulties that may have been experienced in an applicant's life. From this perspective, though the way that race is considered in higher education will shift, its salience may persist.

Notably, we did not include consistency as a treatment; rather, this was inferred by respondents using information that was not provided. In fact, we found that respondents inferred a range of qualities that were not indicated in the vignette itself, including interest in their cultural heritage, being raised by a Black versus a White family, or choosing to attend a Historically Black College or University (HBCU). While we do not explore the underpinnings of these inferences in this study, they do pose interesting questions for future study.

Finally, we acknowledge several limitations of our study that warrant additional scrutiny. First, it is important to note that the respondents in this study are not a monolith: respondents used a range of justifications and reacted in myriad ways to the vignette settings (Thompson et al. 2026). As a result, there are, of course, additional explanations that fall outside of the scope of this article. Second, we acknowledge that our results speak to the boundaries around Blackness specifically but are likely not generalizable to other racial boundaries; however, future research may find this to be a fruitful avenue for exploration. Third, the focus of our study is on free text responses that are part of a larger experiment on racial classifications and evaluations. As a result, we were not able to ask follow-up questions or probe for more information, as we could have if we had interviewed subjects directly. While this presents an important limitation, this method also allowed us to gather a much larger sample size of written reactions ($n = 760$) than

would traditionally be available with other methods. Further, the anonymous nature of our data collection may have allowed respondents to be franker and more forthcoming than they might have otherwise been in an interview setting.

We also intentionally limited the ancestry test results, images, and faces used in this study to a small range of images that were ambiguously White-Black. Therefore, our results are not generalizable to the wider population of individuals who may self-identify as Black, or who may be classified as Black by others. For example, our theory on internal inconsistency may not hold for individuals with no SSA ancestry on their genetic ancestry test results or who do not have other claims to Blackness in their background. Readers may be interested to know how our results apply to high-profile cases like that of Rachel Dolezal, a woman with two White parents who began self-identifying as Black and was met with widespread criticism (Brubaker 2016a). While we cannot speak to her case specifically or to cases of other individuals in similar settings, our results suggest that more consideration ought to be given to perceptions of internal consistency in understanding how moral boundaries are drawn. Finally, because we analyze each respondent's reaction to one fictitious individual, we cannot definitively determine whether respondents' moral frameworks reflect stable individual characteristics or situationally dependent responses. Further, moral reasoning may be related to other factors, such as age, gender, education, or religion, which are beyond the scope of this study. Future work examining moral reasoning should investigate how consistency as a treatment interacts with respondent characteristics across multiple vignettes in order to disentangle the underlying mechanisms.

To conclude, this study builds upon a large body of sociological literatures on the mechanisms underpinning racial conceptions and moral judgments. As the United States becomes increasingly diverse—particularly with an increase in multiracial or racially ambiguous individuals—it becomes increasingly pressing to understand the structure of racial classification logics and the mechanisms that can explain them. We add to this work by introducing conditions under which classifications are likely to be validated and illustrating how what we term *racial consistency* operates as a mark of racial authenticity.

Endnotes

1. Though GATs include the label of "genetic ancestry" in their name, many consider the term *ancestry* to be a misnomer for the information they provide, given that they in fact describe a person's genetic similarity to present-day reference populations, not ancestral populations (Mathieson and Scally 2020; National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine 2023; Trejo and Martschenko 2026).
2. Each respondent was randomly assigned a vignette that varied along three characteristics: (1) recent GAT results (4% vs. 36% sub-Saharan African ancestry), (2) prior racial self-identification (Black vs. non-Black), and (3) the setting in which the vignette individual has chosen to identify as Black (on a census vs. a scholarship intended for Black students). However, as noted later in this section, we focus only on those who were assigned to read a vignette about an individual whose GAT suggested that they had 4% sub-Saharan African genetic similarity (and 96% non-African genetic similarity) who had not previously identified as Black. As a result, the only experimental variation for the data presented for this article is the context in which the vignette individual is self-identifying as Black.
3. Names varied randomly across twelve conditions (six male and six female treatments). For clarity and simplicity, we have chosen one of the names to use in the description of the example vignettes.
4. For the purposes of this study, we focus specifically on those with very small amounts of genetic similarity to sub-Saharan African populations. We do this in part because of wide variation in GAT results among Black Americans. For example, very few Americans who self-identify as Black have GAT results in the 4% SSA ancestry range; indeed, most individuals whose GAT results include less than 28% SSA ancestry (without meaningful amounts of

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other non-European ancestry) self-identify as White or European American (Bryc et al. 2015; Zhang and Trejo forthcoming). As a result, the meaning-making around those with 36% SSA ancestry, a much more common GAT result among self-identified Black Americans, likely reveals different strategies with regard to boundary construction. Around 50% of Americans with 36% SSA self-identify as Black (Trejo and Thompson 2025).

5. Of course, it is possible that respondents may have reacted to the specific name or image that they were assigned. We did not examine whether qualitative themes varied across name and image conditions, which represents a limitation of our analysis. We pretested the images to ensure that they were similar in their degree of White-Black ambiguity, as rated by Black observers. Further, robustness checks on the quantitative outcomes suggest that these manipulations had minimal effects.
6. Given recent widespread use of Large Language Models and their associated chatbots (most notably ChatGPT), readers may be concerned about the collection of our text data. Importantly, we fielded this work in January 2023, less than two months after the release of the early demo version of ChatGPT on November 30, 2022. At the time, most Americans—and presumably most of our survey sample—had not yet heard of ChatGPT (see Figure A2; Pew Research Center 2024).
7. Note that we present all respondent-provided text verbatim, including any errors or formatting choices.

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Supplementary Material

Supplementary Material is available online at *Social Problems* (https://academic.oup.com/socpro)

Conflicts of Interest

None declared.

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